

Resistance in Economic Institutions

PPE Conference Bayreuth

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Who Whom?



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- Leif Wenar: “We do fund human suffering when we make our everyday purchases, and our shopping today does incentivize injustice tomorrow. More, we have been connected to oppression and conflict, corruption and poverty, throughout our lives. As we will see, consumer spending for natural resources prolonged the life of the Soviet regime as well as apartheid in South Africa; it sustained both Pol Pot and Saddam Hussein in power; it helped pay for the genocide in Darfur; and it fired vicious conflicts in Angola and Sierra Leone.” (*Blood Oil*, XIX)

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- Wenar: "This book hopes to present a persuasive case that we should decide to trade in accordance with our own deepest principles—instead of trading in violation of those principles, as we now do. Western countries should change their own rules of trade so as to respect the right of all peoples to take control over their own resources, and so to chart their own fates." (XXVIII)

An Analogy?



Figure 2: There's two dogs in you.

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- *or* consider more closely what can be done in response:
 - ▶ retain the idea that the goods in question are important
 - ▶ expand beyond legal reform
 - ▶ consider means of resistance proportionate to the severity of the problem

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 - ▶ punching someone who punched you
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- because moral rights come with rights to defend them
- under some proper restrictions

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 - ▶ Arridge and Lai & Lim on Ecotage

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- imposing harms in this way violates some people's rights

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 - ★ depending on actual conditions (how bad is it?)
 - ▶ sensitive to the effectiveness of the means of resistance
 - ★ not just stealing because you like money!

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- trade off rights against other goods, e.g. welfare, efficiency etc.

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- another version: „How could they have done otherwise?”
- many possibilities for structuring firms differently!
- or for working in a different job where you're not doing bad things to people

Objection 3: Necessity

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- and also sth. like a „morally weighted costs” view where there's some discount to perpetrators being harmed
- e.g. Finlay 2005 (132): “Necessity demands that agents choose that strategy for achieving the just cause that offers the best possible balance between morally relevant anticipated costs and morally relevant expected gains.”

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- again: err on the side of those who are harmed!

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- liability point seems less concerning to me, although it might substantially shrink the range of plausible addressees

The end

Thank you for listening!

Contact me at: philipp.stehr@hfp.tum.de